

SALMAN'S STORY



BHASKAR PAUL/www.indiatodayimages.com

On September 29, 2002, Salman Khan's Land Cruiser crashed at high speed into the American Express Bakery, Bandra, killing one person and injuring four pavement dwellers. Khan was inebriated at the time of the accident and driving fast according to Ravindra Patil, Khan's bodyguard and prime witness, who was in the car. However, in a predictable twist, Khan claimed the driver was at the wheel and he was a passenger. Four years later, a local court discharged five witnesses after the prosecution said it did not wish to examine them while the other key witnesses injured in the accident turned hostile. The case is pending.

KHAN CLAIMED THAT HIS CAR WAS BEING DRIVEN BY HIS DRIVER AND NOT HIM. THE WITNESSES HAVE TURNED HOSTILE.

in Delhi: "Road safety can only come if all the three partners related to roads are dealt with together—the enforcers or the traffic police, users and those who are living on the roads. But even today traffic is the most ignored department in the police."

That is also reflected in the plethora of agencies responsible for road construction, safety and traffic management of highways. Out of the existing 70,548 km of national highways, 42,469 km is with state Public Works Departments, 19,596 km with the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI), 3,992 km with the Border Roads Organisation (BRO), and 4,491 km is yet to be entrusted to any agency.

In many cases, under the increasingly popular Build, Operate, Transfer (BOT) scheme, stretches of expressways and flyovers are run by private construction companies which tend to cut corners by not sticking to original plans of adequate thoroughways for pedestrians in the form of overbridges or underpasses. Indeed, "vulnerable road users" (pedestrians, cyclists and motorised two-wheeler riders) account for 84 per cent of deaths in cities and 67 per cent on highways. The World Bank has expressed concern over the tardy progress of road safety measures on some of the on-going highway projects in India, saying that no new rules have been framed for safety management despite contracts which provide for safety management, constant monitoring and rating the contractors on these important parameters at worksites.

The GSRRS report emphasises the need for a multi-pronged approach involving psychologists, engineers, doctors, police, sociologists and vehicle experts to deal with road accident deaths as a public health issue. The problem is that road traffic in India essentially remains a civil engineering issue. Says S. Gangopadhyay, director of Central Road Research Institute (CRRI): "As many as 80 per cent of the fatalities on roads involve pedestrians because they are given the least priority." The GSRRS report says: "In many countries (read India) roads are

REUTERS



A VARIETY OF ROAD USERS, INCLUDING NON-MOTORISED VEHICLES AND CATTLE, PROVIDE A BREEDING GROUND FOR MISHAPS

planned and built to allow motor vehicles to travel faster while insufficient thought is given to the needs of pedestrians and cyclists." The homeless who sleep on the road, and form a vulnerable group, are also classified as pedestrians. The 2001 Census estimates that 7,78,599 urban homeless live on roads. Overspeeding was found to be the single biggest reason for pedestrian deaths and injuries. The high profile cases involving Sanjeev Nanda and Salman Khan hitting pedestrians or running over people sleeping on the pavement are not isolated instances. Such cases account for 1,000 pedestrian deaths every year. In Indian cities, the outer areas are generally not provided with subways, pedestrian bridges, paved pavements and zebra crossings. It is here that enforcement of